

Sumerian and Dravidian: Tale of two languages

In this article we compare the two languages, Sumerian and Dravidian, and show broad similarities and differences. Our approach is based on the two Lexicons, the Sumerian Lexicon by Foxvog [1a], Halloran [1b], and the Dravidian Etymology Dictionary (DEDR) by Burrow and Emeneau [2].

We begin with providing a broad outline of the two political systems, their similarities and differences, and then later look at the similarities and differences between the two linguistic systems. Of course, our view of the two political systems were gained in some part with the understanding of the linguistic systems, but the major part of knowledge is gained from the archaeological findings and other historical studies as well. We will only provide a quick summary of the findings.

Political systems of Sumerian and Indus Valley Civilizations

At a broad level the two civilizations were organized along the river that was used to irrigate vast tracks of land, and through the development of organized system of agriculture the townships (ūr) were developed with many professions like carpentry, metal works, cloth making and jewellery. That's were the similarities ends and the stark differences kick-in. Sumerian Civilization (SC) developed a system of kings and temple priests, while Indus Valley Civilization (IVC) had much more egalitarian class society without kings and temples and priestly class. IVC also had a class system but was milder and less exploitative than that of SC. IVC did not have an organized military and constant warfare like SC, but it had a mild form of police force that solves disputes and ensured fair distribution of food and other resources. IVC had a political system of chieftains, as heads of professions, townships and provinces. At function level the IVC managed social and political cohesion through organized system of barter exchanges and group marriages between provinces and towns. In contrast, SC had a strong form of kings, priests and slaves, along with ferocious dogs for enforcing strong controls. We will provide strong linguistic evidences for these claims.

At the core root-word level there are some broad similarities between Sumerian and Dravidian languages, indicating a common origin hypothesis like the Elamo-Dravidian hypothesis. However, as we get into structural details, we discover that the morphological structures are organized on very different core principles, especially that in many cases the Sumerian is pre-affixing, while Dravidian is post-affixing. At the semantic level, the Sumerian is linguistically rich in personal nouns and individualistic attitudes, while Dravidian provides rich adjectives to describe collective professional identities in various skills and professions.

Sumerian language

Our study of Sumerian language is mostly based on the Sumerian Lexicon developed by Foxvog [1a], and Halloran [1b]. The Sumerian language is an agglutinative language and can be constructed morphologically from it's root-word syllables. It is generally assumed that languages pre-exist as

speech and the logo-syllabic structures are just an expression of that fact. We find this a fallacious argument and that in fact that the language itself is reflection of it's logo-syllabic origins. The new form of society that Sumerian Civilization brought into being created an entirely new set of social situation with it's emergent nouns and adjectival descriptors. This provided a new outlook and structure to the pre-existing speech-language through the emergent logo-graphic/logo-syllabic writing system.

We will start with only some core prefix syllables but for a detailed account please refer to Foxvog [1a], and Halloran [1b].

Base syllables

a, e ₄	water, tears (noun); in favor of (suffix); the (article).
é	as house, temple, land
i	cry of pain (noun); to capture, defeat (verb).
ú	plant, vegetable, food, bread, pasture (noun); nourish (verb); strong (adjective).
ù	sleep (noun); to sleep (verb).
ù	sleep (noun); to sleep (verb).
u ₅	male bird, cock (noun); to mount, to ride (verb); high, raised land (adjective).
éd, è; i	to emerge, send forth, become visible.
èd, e ₁₁	to exit, to descend, to bring down.
ud, u ₄	sun, light, day, weather, time.
ég, ék, íg, e	embankment, dike (noun); to water, to speak (verb); in, toward (preposition).
ig	door, entrance.
ug ⁽²⁾	lion; anger, fury; storm.
ug _{4,5,7,8}	death; dead person (noun); to kill (verb).
ul	joy, pleasure, satisfaction; star; flower; bud; ornament; a capacity measure (noun); to glitter, shine (verb); remote, distant in time; ancient, enduring (adjective).
ul ₄	to be quick; to hurry, hasten, harass.
an	sky, heaven, the god (noun); to be high (verb); high (adjective); in front (preposition).
en	dignitary; lord, high priest, ancestor (noun); to rule (verb); noble (adjective).
en ^(2,3)	time, enigmatic (noun); until (preposition).
in	he, she, straw, insult, offense.

lu	many, much; man, men, people; sheep (noun); to be/make numerous, abundant; to multiply (verb).
lú	grown man, male, human being, someone, gentleman
uru ₍₂₎ ^(ki)	town/village
uru ₄ , ur ₁₁ (-ru)	plough
uru ₉	strong
úrgu	growl, bark (dog)
ur	dog, carnivorous beast, servant, young man, warrior, enemy (noun); to tremble (verb); humble (adjective).
udu	sheep, goat
iti, izi	fire, moonlight, moon, month
ul	joy, to glitter, shine
ni, na	he/she, that one
-na	human being
na ₄	pebble, tiny
pa _{4,5,6} (-ra)	irrigation ditch, dike
mu, mug	word, speech

The fact that the syllable, ur, occurs with semantic associations to “dog, carnivorous beast, servant, young man, warrior, enemy, strong” and úrgu to dog-bark indicate the role of trained ferocious beasts as a means of autocratic rule by lords in Sumerian Civilization seems a strong possibility. In the case of IVC, the same syllable, ur, had quite different semantic associations as we shall see.

Dravidian language

The inner workings of the etymology of proto-Dravidian, as enunciated by Burrow and Emeneau [2] and Krishnamurti [3] fit perfectly with the inner workings of the logo-syllabic script, thus leading to the conclusion that the script could have acted as a crucial mechanism for the birth of the proto-Dravidian language. The agglutinative aspect of proto-Dravidian could also have arisen from the topological aspect of the script that allows the base signs to combine through an additive/multiplicative welding process. This has many uncanny resemblances to the work of a skilled coppersmith.

U – ū

(flesh/meat/body: DEDR 728)

(uṇ, ūṇ, uṇa, uṇā, ūṭṭa, ūṭṭā, ūṭṭu, ūṭṭam: DEDR 600)

Food is indicated by the shape of a bowl/mortar (ural, urī: DEDR 651, 708) used to store/process/distribute food. This is quite similar to the proto-Sumerian sign of bowl , which

combines with human head  to produce the verb “eat”:

 +  = 

In the Indus script, the process of affixing is quite similar. Next, the manner in which the logo for two “iru” combines with the logo for food  to produce the town is presented here:

|| – iru

(fix permanently, great, spacious, vast: DEDR 480, 481)

ū + iru = uru

(numerous/abundant/large: DEDR 711)

The village/town/city is a vast aggregation of many (a body of) people, so the ideogram of “flesh and the body” combines with the ideogram of “vastness/fixedness” to produce a large aggregation of people – the town.

𑀓 = U + || = ū + iru = ūr

(village/town/city, DEDR 752)

(uru, ūr, ūru, ūṇru, ūṛru, ūṭa: DEDR 749, 761, 763)

ūr also has many connotations (as shown above) such as dwelling, fixed, strong (fortified) and plenty of food.

𑀔 = U + | = ū + mutal ≈ uḷ

(truth/soul/inside/pestle, DEDR 697, 698, 672)

uḷ also has many connotations (as shown above) such as truth, a big heart and plenty of possessions.

(uḷ, ulakkai, uḷḷa, uḷi, uḷḷam/uḷḷamai, uḷḷavan DEDR 749, 761, 763)

𑀕 = U + 𑀗 = uḷ + -an ≈ uḷḷavan

(rich man, man with possessions, DEDR 697)

Another short syllabic equivalent form of 𑀗-an is:

𑀘 = no

(tiny, small: DEDR 3779).

So the following is established,

$$\mathbb{U} = \cup + | + \text{⋮} = \bar{u} + \text{mutal} + \text{no} \approx \text{uṭan}$$

(together with, agreement: DEDR 945)

U-uṭan has ideographic similarity with the mortar-and-pestle sign, which has a Dravidian cultural association with marriage. This is also the joining together of souls, uḷḷam.

This is further reinforced by the concordance:

$$\mathbb{U}\mathbb{U} = \text{uṭan} + \text{nāṇ}$$

(joining together in agreement)

where

$$\mathbb{U} = \text{nə} + \text{mutal} + \text{nə} = \text{nāṇ}$$

(marriage thread containing a badge of agreement, DEDR 2908)

Ūr-cluster

U, U, U, U, U

ūr – town/village, uḷ – inside, ū – meat/body, uṛu – to plough, uṭan – with/together, uravu – relatives, uruku – melt

The underlying basis of the creation of a town is farming, and melting of the soil by ploughing is fundamental to farming. The hard-consonant grinds/melts to produce the soft consonant, retroflex ɻ, thus ūr, ūru (town/village) produces ūṛu (to plough). The town then blossoms into many forms of towns: UṪU - velūr - hunter-town, UṪU - xempūr/cempūr – bronzesmith town.

Affix Base				⋮	⋮	Ψ	-	⌘†Ψ
U	U	U	U	U	U	UṪU	UṪU	UṪU
Ū	uḷ	ūr	ūm	uṭan	uṭanai	velūr	chevūr	vel-aṇi-nuṛan-ūr

Pa-cluster



The sun is central to any civilization and the word cluster is below:

pakal – day(light), pal – teeth/many, palli – hamlet, perum-puli – leopard/tiger, para – drum/message, pammu – stitch, palla – tusk/elephant, pānan – singer, para/pori – fly/bird, pura – pigeon

The homophony between pigeon (pura) and messaging (para) suggests that messages were also sent through pigeons or that this practice was well known. There is also have para – to spread (like a bird).

Comment: ☉ was correctly identified as para (drum) by Bryan Wells [10, p. 90-91].

Affix						☐	☐	☐	☐	-
Base	☉	☉	☉	☉	☉	☉	☉	☉	☉	☉
pa	pal	para	pammu	nal- para	pallā	vel-appa	pān	pānal	pān-an	nal-pallar

Ta-cluster



The cool pot that stores water in hot weather also becomes the root syllable for other root words: tandi/tavalai – pot/frog, tan – cool (as in tan-nir) , taḷ – push, tai – tailor, taṛi – burial pot, taṭṭi – bronzesmith, grid, mat, taṭṭu – to tinker, toṭṭi – rake.

Affix		☐			☐		☐	-	☐
Base	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
ta (tandi)	taḷ	tan	tai	irutai	ciṛuttai	mumutai	tāṛi	todu, toṭu	tan

Ka-cluster



The fort is the central structure around which the Indus society operates. The kovan – the cattle farmer – is the basis of this higher structure. The chieftains with adorning horns (kompan) form the basis for this. The fish-sign aligns with the travelling vehicle, the boat (the artificial gharial or the fish). Although the word kaṇṇi does not denote a boat (as there is no evidence for a boat/gharial in DEDR), it is related to kā – carry, katattu – transport. The direct root syllable for fish is mīṇ, which is also related to miṇ, minu, miṇukkal – sparkling, minal – lightning, but it is proposed that the ma syllable is taken by another semantic group of logograms, creating a pictographic branching pattern. Even the word “shining” when it has other bright connotations, takes a different pa-syllable form of paḷa-paḷa, with origins to the pakal – sun and pal – shining teeth (pal-pala also denotes several teeth).

kōnda, gōnde – bull, kō – highness, kōṭa – fort, kaṇṇi – boat, trap, kāl – vehicle, kōl – boat, koḷ – receive/buy.

Comment: ◇ was correctly identified as kō by Bryan Wells [10, p. 98].

 Affix Base			^	^		
						
kanni	kāl	kōl	peru-kanni	peru-mu-kanni	kōnda, gōnde	kannal

Va-cluster

),))),),), D, D, (, (

This is another highly cohesive homophonic cluster.

vala – right, val – strong, vāḷ – sword, vaḷa/vaḷai/vaḷainci - curve/bend, valai – capture/net, valaiyan – fisherman/trapper, vil – bow, vaṛi – way, vāṛ/yaṛ – joy/dance/music/harp, iṭai – left, iṭaiyan – herder.

 Affix Base	180°	◦	◦ 180°	- 180°				
)	(	)	(	)(	D	Ø	Ø	))
valai	iṭai	valaiyan	iṭaiyan	iṭa	vil	vilampu	vila-vila	iru-valai

Ma-cluster

𑌕, 𑌕, 𑌕, 𑌕, 𑌕, 𑌕

The well-fortified forts used raised-floor constructions to avoid flooding.

mē – high, west, māṭi – terrace, māṭu – buffalo, māran – barterer, mūmalai – three/mature-mountain.

 Affix Base		𑌕		𑌕		U	^	* ^
𑌕	𑌕	𑌕	𑌕	𑌕	𑌕	𑌕	𑌕	𑌕
mēl	mēl	mēl-mēl	mē-mū	mē-vēl	māṭi	māṭu	mēl-poruḷ	mū-iru-mēl-poruḷ

Na-cluster

𐎠, 𐎡, 𐎢, 𐎣, 𐎤, 𐎥

no! – tiny (bug, droplet), nāṭu - country/province, nuran, nulampu – mosquito, stitching, nān – thread (marriage thread), aniyal, mani – necklace, beads, nal-nel-āl – good farmer.

Affix								
Base								
𐎠	𐎡	𐎢	𐎣	𐎤	𐎥	𐎦	𐎧	𐎨
-n	nāṭu-	anīyal, maṇi	nulṭān, nuṣan	nān	nan	nannu, nannan	nalnelāl	nan- mutal

Ca-cluster

𐎠, 𐎡, 𐎢, 𐎣

cil – piece (chip), cippu – shell, cira - excel, cirappu – excellent, stitching, ciṭu-ciṭ-eṇal – lively, bubbly

Affix						
Base						
𐎠	𐎡	𐎢	𐎣	𐎤	𐎥	𐎦
cil	cira	cirappu	nērcira	nērcira-kō	ciṭu-ciṭ-eṇal	ciṭu-ciṭ-eṇal-mutalvan

Xe/Ke/Ce-cluster

𐎠, 𐎡, 𐎢

xe/ke/ce – red, xembu – bronze, xeval – chicken/bronze, xeviyān – hare/bronzesmith, cevūr – bronzetown.

Dravidian is also an agglutinative language like Sumerian, but the agglutination process is post-affixing and not pre-affixing like Sumerian.

Similarities between the languages

Sumerian [1]	Dravidian [2]	English
ú	ū, un	food, flesh
uru ₍₂₎ ^(ki)	ūr/ūru	town, village
uru ₄ , ur ₁₁ (-ru)	uṛu	to plough, till
uru ₉	ura	firm, strong
udu	āṭu	sheep, goat
úrgu	urumu	growl, bark (dog)
iti, izi	tī, tiṅkaḷ	fire, moonlight, moon, month

Sumerian [1]	Dravidian [2]	English
ul	oḷi	joy, to glitter, shine
ni, na	ni, na	he/she, that one
-na	-an	human being
na ₄	no	pebble, tiny
pa _{4,5,6} (-ra)	paḷḷam	irrigation ditch, dike
um	mu	old
mu, mug	moṛi	word, speech
ten, te-en	tan	cold
gir, giri, girim	kaḷi	clay, glide, creep
gil, gili, gilim	vala, valai, vaḷa, vaḷai	bent, bow
kalam	kaḷam, kalam	land for threshing, vessel, ship
kankal	karu-nilam, tarisu	blacksoil, hard soil, uncultivated land
ugu	ucci	top (of head)
sag, sa ₁₂	caṭai, mutal	crest, head, first
siki, síg	caṭai, cuṭṭi, cūṭi	crest, hair (of head)
kur	kūr	sharp, mountain
ama	ammā	mother

Divergences between the languages

Sumerian [1]	Dravidian [2]	English
mu, mug	moṛi	word, speak
engar	uṛa(-an)	farmer
enku	vala(an)	fisherman
enkum	mu-an	temple treasurer
engiz	u-an	cook
énsi(-k)	mutal-an	city ruler
ten, te-en	tan	cold
gir, giri, girim	kaḷi	clay, glide, creep
gil, gili, gilim	vala, valai, vaḷa, vaḷai	bent, bow
kankal	karu-nilam, tarisu	blacksoil, hard soil, uncultivated land
babbar ₍₂₎	paḷa, pakal	daylight, bright
eš, -lu	pala	many
nir, ner	tala, tavalā	frog

Agglutination of syllables in Sumerian and Dravidian

Although both languages have similar affix “en/an” to denote humans and lords/chiefs, this suffix is a prefix in Sumerian while it is a post-position affix in Dravidian. This important post-affixing agglutination and it’s relation to the Indus script was first noted by the Russian school [4] (Knorozov, 1964).

Sumerian	Dravidian
engar (farmer) = en (lord) + agar (land)	uṛavan = uṛu (plough) + an (man)
endub (cook) = en (lord) + dub (shake)	uvan (cook) = u (food) + an (man)
enku (fisherman) = en (lord) + ku ₆ /kua (fish)	valaiyan (fisherman/trapper) = valai (net) + an (man)
^(lú-) en-nu(-un) (guardian) = en + nu	kavalan (guardian) = ka (guard) + an (man)
simug = si (red) + mug (engrave)	ceviyan (smith) = ce (red) + an (man)
lú-gi-gíd/id (piper/flutist) = lú (man) + gi (reed) + gíd (long)	panan (singer) = pan (song) + an (man)
un-saḡ-ḡi ₆ (black-head-people) = un (people) + saḡ (head) + ḡi (black)	parayan (messenger) = para (drum) + an (man)
um-mi ₍₃₎ -a = um (wise) + mi (officer)	mu-iru-mel-porul = mu (mature/old) + iru (big) + mel (high) + porul (object)
un-íl-me (labor) = un (people) + il (to carry) + me (to be)	kiran (poor) = kir (below) + an (man)

Conclusion

In this brief article we have shown the similarity and differences in the two language systems, Sumerian and Dravidian. The differences in attitudes are quite clear. Sumerian is an advanced class society with kings, priests and temples and greater extraction of surplus with both intellectual advancement and individual excesses like warfare and instability. The Sumerian language is also well developed with greater individualistic theoretical advances. The Proto-Dravidian of IVC on the other hand is an oasis of stability and peace with greater skill development in many professions. It is hypothesized that the Sumerian language promotes human affixes to the beginning as pre-position affixes, while IVC Proto-Dravidian promotes the professional affixes to the beginning and the individual affixes as post-position affixes. This points to the collective professional attitude and the suppressed individualism with reduced inequality in the IVC class society.

References

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